

A Question of Scale: How Wealthy Is Brazil?

In 2014, Brazil hosted the men's World Cup soccer competition. In 2016, it hosted the Summer Olympics. These two events brought Brazil worldwide attention and symbolized the country's dramatic rise in global standing. With an area nearly equal to the United States and a population of more than 200 million, Brazil has arrived. Not long ago, Brazil was considered a **developing nation**. Now, however, Brazil appears ready to compete with the economic powerhouses of the world.

Brazil's economic growth has not come quickly or smoothly. In the late 15th century, Portugal colonized the region with the main intention of making money for itself. Its focus was to grow and sell sugarcane. To meet the labor needs of sugar production, Portugal imported slaves from Africa by the millions. In 1822, when Brazil won its independence from Portugal, roughly half of Brazil's population were slaves.

During much of its history, and well into the 20th century, Brazil wrestled with two particular problems. One problem was overreliance on **cash crops** like sugar, rubber, and coffee. Cash crops were exported to other countries to bring wealth to Brazil. By the early 1900s, coffee made up about half of Brazil's export earnings. At times, the economy boomed. But all was not good. Because Brazil depended so heavily on coffee sales, whenever global demand for coffee went down, Brazil's economy went into a tailspin.

A second problem was that for four centuries, Brazil had essentially two **social classes**: landlords and plantation laborers. Even after slavery ended in 1888, most of the wealth was concentrated in the hands of the landlords; very little of the profit

trickled down to the workers. The few rich stayed rich, and the many poor stayed poor.

Brazil's response to these two problems was **industrialization**. The idea was to borrow from foreign countries, invest in factories, and create a **diverse economy** that was not so dependent on cash crops. Industrialization would also spread the wealth by creating a new middle class of factory and business workers.

Progress has been choppy. Brazil seems to be overcoming its worst economic difficulties. The country has abundant resources, and foreign

investment has increased dramatically. However, at times, Brazilian officials have had trouble paying off overseas debt. Programs that help poor people are expensive, too. Many people looking for jobs in



cities have moved into **favelas**, or slums, and although many residents belong to the middle class, favelas remain hotbeds of violence and corruption. All this background brings us back to the matter of Brazil's wealth.

When geographers try to understand complicated issues such as the wealth of a nation, they must consider **scale**. Scale is a geographical concept which takes into consideration the size of the area under investigation. When you investigate Brazil, for example, are you going to look at the whole country's wealth, the wealth of a particular region, or even the wealth of a neighborhood? The scale you choose will influence what you see and what conclusions you draw.

For this Mini-Q, your task is to analyze Brazil's wealth at three different scales: national, regional, and local. Then answer the question: *A question of scale: how wealthy is Brazil?*

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